

Straight from **THE HEART**

"I feel I'm a special person and if someone does something to me, I just remove myself from that person's life"

"My brain is like a computer in its memory for scripts. It just soaks everything in and then it's in my head at all times. I'm often thinking of the part and it starts coming to me. Then I start collecting the information. Often it's not thought out."

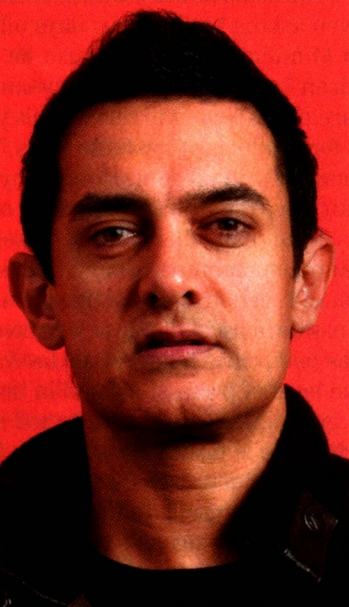
"The two mistakes I made early on was signing nine films within six months of my debut and giving too much importance to scripts, not directors."

"A star's dependability is measured by his unsuccessful films. Whatever business it does is because of him."

"I was 16 when I realised I wanted to be an actor. My school friend Aditya Bhattacharya decided to cast me in a 40-minute silent film called *Paranoia*, financed with Rs 8,000 from actor Shriram Lagoo. Making that film convinced me that this is where I belonged. Shabana Azmi saw it and told my parents. All hell broke loose."

"Seeing my father go bankrupt when his film *Locket* was stuck for eight years taught me to be responsible to the market."

"My first instinct when I go home is to pick up a book, not the remote. I've been reading since I was six."



UMESH GOSWAMI/www.indiatodayimages.com



KHAN WITH HIRANI (RIGHT) AT A PROMOTIONAL TOUR OF NAGPUR FOR 3 IDIOTS

films. He says he learnt that lesson early on when he signed a spate of films in a hurry on the basis of their scripts and then realised the director's vision was completely different from his. He recalls that when he was at his lowest point, having been dismissed as a one film wonder, it was Mahesh Bhatt who offered him a hand, discussing a script with him, which as luck would have it, he didn't like it. "He was at the peak of his talent, having just done *Saaransh*, *Arth* and *Naam* and I didn't know how I could tell him I didn't like his script. So I bought time, came home and asked Reena. She told me to follow my heart. I did, telling Bhattsaab that I wanted to do instead was a remake of one of my favourite films, *Roman Holiday*, with Sridevi. He listened but then took out a screenplay of Frank Capra's 1934 film *It Happened One Night*. Six months later, we would do the film together as *Dil Hai Ki Manta Nahin*." That's a lesson of following his happiness that he hasn't forgotten since then. It's taught him to do things his way, to go with his gut instinct even when every practical sense is screaming no, as it did when Mehra narrated *Rang De Basanti* to him, which was coming on the heels of four Bhagat Singh flops. And if he still needs advice, he turns to Hussain, who is producer Nasir Hussain's daughter, and actor Imran Khan's mother. "She's one person I go to when I need to talk about anything," he says warmly. "She's a great thinker."

Stardom sits simply on him. Yes, there are the six bodyguards who travel everywhere with him. His man Friday Sachin, his girl Friday Sarita, and his manager Binki seem to stay awake all night. There is also the flashy Toyota Landcruiser and the Rs 10-crore sprawling house in Panchgani. But Khan is essentially a middle-class man, who thinks nothing of upturning the Body Shop shower gel to catch the last drop or blindly trusting his accountant of 20 years to invest his money well. It's ingrained in him because his most formative years, eight to 14, were spent in the shadow of his father, producer Tahir Hussain's imminent bankruptcy. "My father spent eight years making a film called *Locket* which was stalled because actors wouldn't